It was a great pleasure for me to flag off the ‘first’ women’s Everest expedition launched by the army on 18 March 2005. This expedition made history as for the first time, the Indian Army successfully put on the summit four courageous women – Captains Sipra Mazumdar and Ashwini Pawar, Cadet Tshering Ladol and trainee Dechen Lhamo – and five more members of the support team on 2 June 2005. This included Major (now Colonel) S.S. Shekhawat. This expedition used the northern route to climb the peak known as ‘Sagarmatha’, the Nepalese name of the Everest, or ‘Chomolungma’, the Goddess Mother of the World in Tibetan, and had to approach the peak from Lhasa in Tibet because of the disturbed conditions in Nepal.



Major D.J. Singh of the Maratha Light Infantry and his team on the summit of Everest.

It was also my desire that an expedition comprising officers and men from the Maratha Light Infantry should scale the Everest during my tenure as the chief. Accordingly, the selection and